THE SCIENCE OF STRESS

- WHY IT HAS BECOME AN EPIDEMIC IN INDIA
- LATEST RESEARCH ON HOW IT AFFECTS THE BODY
- NEW WAYS TO MANAGE STRESS

By **SONALI ACHARJEE**

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Kusum Negi, 41, a marketing executive based in West Delhi, was at an office meeting when she felt a sharp, stabbing pain at the back of her neck and had to be rushed to the emergency room. A neck brace and painkillers relieved her immediate misery, but the doctors didn't find anything in her bones or muscles that could explain the trigger. Then Negi mentioned stress, and things began falling into place. "An orthopaedist told me that stress can cause inflammation, which, in turn, can lead to muscle seizures," says Negi, recalling her plight four months ago. "I hadn't exactly been feeling peaceful, but I never realised it could lead to muscle spasms."